routes and ensure economic security in the free and open Indo-Pacific region."[116] Even though India's endeavours at enhancing its naval capabilities through internal and external efforts under Modi are at the softer end of the balancing scale, in particular the external efforts, they do reflect an Indian willingness to secure its interests in the IOR and, taken as a whole, indicate an emerging rivalry with China in the maritime domain.

Assessing India's China policy under Modi

India's China policy and actions are marked by increased co-operation but also by increased disagreement and rivalry. India, under Modi, is engaging in growing economic interaction and co-operation with China, as this chapter has shown. But it is also taking a tough stance on its dispute with China over the border in the Himalayas. It is clearly engaged in a rivalry with China in the IOR, and it is establishing closer ties with the United States. And yet Modi is also simultaneously seeking to "reset" bilateral relations with China, as signalled by his meeting with Xi Jinping in Wuhan. Given such a mix of policies and actions, is it possible to conclude whether India is moving towards more cooperation or more confrontation and, in terms of IR theory, whether it is adopting cooperative, extensive, or conflictive hedging, vis-à-vis China?

With respect to military and hard security indicators, India, although still spending relatively less on its navy than are many other maritime nations, has identified the Indian Ocean Region as an area of great importance to its interests. New Delhi is acquiring new, high-end naval capabilities in the form of aircraft carriers and SSBNs, which